edoc Scriptus

Innovative Staffing Strategies

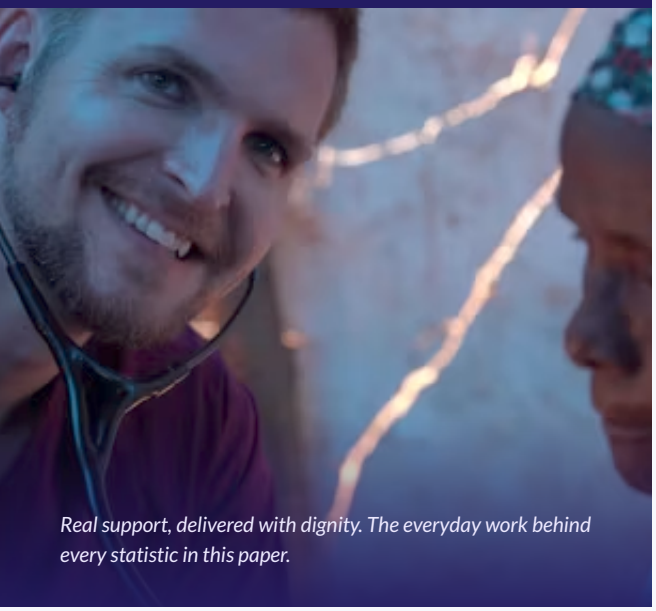
Future of Hospice Care

2026

Whitepaper

www.edocscriptus.com

Compassionate care starts with a strong workforce. Innovation empowers hospice teams to deliver dignity and comfort.



Real support, delivered with dignity. The everyday work behind every statistic in this paper.

Strengthening Hospice Teams

Hospice care is one of the most human professions there is. And right now, the people who deliver it are stretched thin. Staffing shortages are not new, but in 2026 they have reached a point where they directly threaten the quality of care patients receive at the most vulnerable moments of their lives. For administrators, clinical leaders, and operators alike, finding a sustainable path forward is no longer optional.

Hospice News recently shared its outlook survey on the state of the hospice and palliative care marketplaces. In that report, which included C-level executives, operators, and managers, respondents named staffing "the greatest challenge in hospice."[1]

#1 Industry executives rank staffing as the single greatest challenge facing hospice today, ahead of reimbursement, regulation, and competition.[1]

With that in mind, this paper examines the following:

- Key points related to the current-day hospice workforce challenges
- The opportunity for innovative workforce staffing solutions
- The potential for technology to support staff and staffing solutions

Scriptus

AI plus human-verified documentation for hospice care teams. You will see how it fits throughout this paper.

Current-Day Hospice Workforce Challenges

The hospice industry has been facing significant staffing constraints for several years, and the COVID-19 pandemic worsened some of these shortages.[2] Several issues are contributing to workforce challenges:



Aging Workforce and the Retirement of Highly Qualified Professionals

An aging workforce, and impending retirements of existing staff members, can lead to a shortage of experienced clinicians. When experienced professionals exit the profession, they take a great deal of knowledge with them, and beneficial mentorship relationships may decline. At the same time, attracting younger professionals to the field has been challenging given limited exposure to end-of-life care and the demanding nature of the work.

We hope to see that as more professionals retire, hospice and home health organizations will be able to replace experienced staff while still maintaining strong mentorship programs to support knowledge transfer. Organizations that plan for this transition now, rather than reacting to it later, will hold a real advantage in the decade ahead.

The through-line. Experience is leaving the field faster than it is being replaced. Mentorship, knowledge transfer, and day-to-day clinician support are now urgent operational priorities, and the organizations that invest in them will keep their strongest people.

A Rising Number of Staff Impacted by Burnout



Compassion fatigue, a state in which clinicians are emotionally, mentally, and physically drained by their roles, has been rising among healthcare professionals for years.[6,7] In many settings, clinicians feel they are asked to do more with less. Leadership is often aware of the problem, but solutions are hard to put in place, and the exhaustion builds.

A study by Eun-Ju Cho and Hun Ha Cho found that nurses working at specialized hospice and palliative care facilities "are among the most sensitive groups for compassion fatigue."[4,5] 78% experienced a moderate or higher level of compassion fatigue, and roughly 26% had severe compassion fatigue.[4,5,6] That dynamic plays a direct role in turnover and lost productivity.[5]

What often goes undiscussed is how much administrative burden contributes to this fatigue. Documentation alone can consume hours of a clinician's day. And when that documentation is powered solely by AI, the burden doesn't disappear. It shifts, as clinicians spend their time reviewing, correcting, and validating AI-generated notes instead of caring for patients.

That is why the approach matters. Scriptus pairs advanced AI with experienced human editors, so clinicians are never left cleaning up after an automated system. AI captures and structures the clinical conversation, and human editors provide the quality assurance hospice documentation demands. The result: less time documenting, less time editing, more time with patients.

78% of hospice and palliative care nurses report moderate or higher compassion fatigue[4,5]. **Burnout is not inevitable.** Scriptus exists to give that time back: less paperwork, more patient care.

Hiring and Retention Challenges

The hospice and home health care sectors face substantial challenges hiring and retaining team members. A significant factor is a competitive job market that's held for several years, and with growing wage pressures, many providers say it is difficult to keep up with the salary and compensation packages needed to attract and retain top talent.

Taken together, these factors, plus growing demand for hospice services, intensify the strain on staffing resources today. Addressing them is critical to upholding high standards of patient care.

Increased Demand for Hospice Services

Demand for hospice and similar services is a trend expected to continue: palliative care need is projected to increase by 42% by 2040, growing out of proportion to deaths, driven by an aging population, a rise in chronic illnesses, and growing awareness of the benefits of hospice care.[9,10]



The Nature of Current Staffing Models

Current (or traditional) staffing models can be a problem when it comes to attracting and retaining talent. Hospice team members have reported “difficulties with taking time off from work and maintaining work-life integration” as one of the issues with their roles.[8,14]

Beyond this inflexibility, hospice employers also have challenges with the current staffing model: employing full-time staff is increasingly expensive, and rising labor costs across salaries, benefits, and recruitment make up a large share of operating budgets, with high turnover adding even more pressure.[11,12]

The financial pressure is being felt at the highest levels of the industry. Joel Wherley, President and COO of VITAS Healthcare, one of the nation's largest hospice providers, put it plainly in a conversation with Hospice News: organizations have had to significantly increase labor expenses simply to survive. The path forward, he noted, requires rethinking how hospice care is delivered and sustained.[11]

Edoc Service understands this reality firsthand. Through a well-established partnership with VITAS Healthcare, Edoc has transcribed millions of lines of clinical documentation across hospice settings, building the kind of operational trust that only comes from years of consistent, accurate, compliant work at scale.

The pattern is clear. Rigid staffing models are expensive for employers and exhausting for clinicians, and the pressure compounds as demand for hospice care keeps rising.

How Innovation and Technology Can Alleviate Staffing Strains

Innovative staffing models and advancements in technology can be pivotal in mitigating workforce challenges. Gig staffing models, paired with strategic investments in staff engagement, offer promising strategies to enhance flexibility, cost-effectiveness, and job satisfaction within hospice organizations.

18%
of hospice providers name staff engagement a primary investment focus

1 in 3
plan to invest in operational process improvements

Adaptable Staffing Models

The adoption of gig staffing models introduces on-demand platforms and flexible scheduling, enabling organizations to efficiently manage fluctuating patient needs and reduce labor costs.[15,16,17] Investing in staff engagement is also gaining traction: about 18% of respondents identified "staff engagement as a primary focus of their investments", and nearly one-third plan to invest in operational process improvements.[1,13]

Flexible staffing models create new documentation challenges, too. When care teams rotate, part-time clinicians cover shifts, and new staff are onboarded quickly, the consistency and accuracy of clinical notes becomes harder to maintain. This is exactly where purpose-built documentation technology becomes not just helpful, but essential.

Scriptus is designed to flex with your organization. It adapts to your preferred formatting, your terminology, and the shortcuts and workflows your clinicians already rely on. It molds to the way your team works, rather than asking your team to change for it.

Benefits of Adaptable Staffing Models in Hospice

Implementing a more agile staffing model offers advantages including:

Increased Flexibility
Both employers and workers benefit from adaptable scheduling, allowing for better work-life balance and responsiveness to patient care demands.

The Potential for Cost Savings
Utilizing part-time and contract workers can lead to financial efficiencies, scaling staffing levels without long-term financial commitments.

Greater Scalability
Hospices can quickly adjust staffing levels to meet patient needs, ensuring continuity of care during periods of increased demand.

Enhanced Engagement & Satisfaction
Offering flexible work options can improve job satisfaction among healthcare professionals and has a meaningful impact on retention.

The bottom line. Flexibility, cost savings, scalability, and stronger engagement are not separate wins. They compound. Hospices that pair adaptable staffing with purpose-built documentation technology are best positioned to weather the workforce shortage without sacrificing care quality.

Challenges and Considerations for Hospice Leaders

An adaptable workforce brings real advantages, and it also raises the bar in three areas every hospice leader should plan for:

Ensuring Continuity of Care for Patients

Maintaining consistent patient care can be challenging with a rotating workforce. Developing comprehensive handover protocols and communication strategies is essential to ensure seamless care transitions.

Maintaining Quality

Hospices must implement rigorous training and oversight mechanisms to ensure that all staff members adhere to established care standards. This can be more challenging with a greater number of staff, and with part-time and rotational staff.

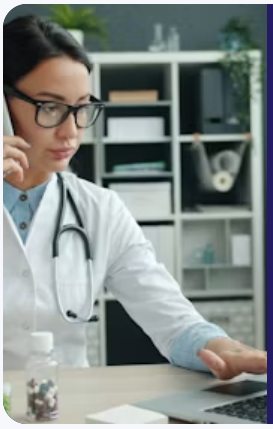
Regulatory Compliance

Navigating the complexities of labor laws and healthcare regulations is critical, and with a more agile workforce, this only becomes harder.[20,21] Consistent, accurate clinical documentation is one of the most important lines of defense an organization has when it comes to regulatory compliance. Every note matters.

The opportunity. A more adaptable staffing model, backed by targeted investments in staff engagement, can meaningfully ease staffing strains in hospice care while improving resource use and patient outcomes.

The Opportunity of Technology

Hospice organizations are increasingly turning to technology to enhance operational efficiency and alleviate workforce strains, streamlining administrative tasks so healthcare professionals can focus more on patient care.



AI-Powered Scheduling & Matching Algorithms

AI analyzes patient admissions, staff availability, and operational capacity to optimize the allocation of human and material resources.[22]

> *"Nurses entering the workforce need a wider scope of hospice and palliative care education and awareness to help fill these knowledge gaps and prepare them for growing demand," explained Michelle White, director of home and transitional care and homecare providers at North Carolina-based Cone Health.*[3]

While the industry works toward closing that education gap, hospice organizations cannot afford to wait. New clinicians entering the workforce need tools that support them from day one, reducing the margin for documentation error while they build clinical experience. This is precisely where Scriptus plays a quiet but critical role: a safety net of human-reviewed, compliance-ready documentation that protects both the clinician and the patient record.

3.6M+ **patient reports delivered.** Technology cannot replace clinical judgment, but it can protect it. Behind every Scriptus note stands a human editor and two decades of hospice documentation experience.

Telehealth & Remote Patient Monitoring

Telehealth and remote patient technologies have become integral to extending the reach of hospice care, and as demand grows, this access will only become more critical. These tools let clinicians monitor symptoms, stay in touch with patients who otherwise wouldn't be seen, manage pain, and connect families to resources, all while keeping patients on hospice, out of the hospital, and with loved ones.[23]

Digital Onboarding Platforms

Efficient onboarding and continuous education are crucial for maintaining a competent hospice workforce. A better onboarding experience translates to a better overall employee experience, which can be critical for retention.



150M+	3.6M+	20+
Lines transcribed since 2015	Patient reports delivered	Years serving hospice & palliative care

Verified Scriptus / Edoc figures, HIPAA-compliant operations.

Technology and trust, working together. From telehealth and digital onboarding to AI-assisted documentation, the tools reshaping hospice operations all point toward the same goal: giving clinicians back the time and confidence to focus on patients, not paperwork. Edoc and Scriptus have spent more than two decades earning that trust, one report at a time.

Scriptus

Enhancing Documentation Efficiency with Scriptus

For hospice clinicians, documentation is one of the heaviest administrative burdens they carry. It pulls them away from patients, feeds burnout, and, when done inconsistently, creates real compliance risk for the organization.

Scriptus was built specifically to address this. Unlike fully automated tools that generate AI output and leave clinicians to review and correct it, Scriptus takes a hybrid approach: advanced AI captures and structures clinical conversations in real time, while experienced human editors provide the quality assurance, clinical judgment, and accuracy hospice documentation demands. The result is documentation clinicians can trust without spending hours verifying it.

Scriptus also adapts to the way your organization works. Preferred formatting, organization-specific terminology, and established workflows are all built in, so adoption is seamless rather than disruptive. With a well-established partnership with leading hospice providers including VITAS Healthcare, and millions of lines of clinical documentation transcribed, Scriptus brings a depth of experience that generic tools simply can't match.

For organizations navigating staff turnover, flexible staffing models, and growing compliance demands, Scriptus is not just a documentation tool. It is infrastructure for sustainable, high-quality hospice care.

Looking into the Future with Scriptus

The staffing crisis in hospice is real, and it is not going away. Organizations that invest in the right tools today will be better positioned to retain their best clinicians, maintain compliance, and deliver the quality of care their patients deserve. Scriptus combines AI efficiency with human expertise. It is not just a technology solution; it is a commitment to getting it right, every note, every patient, every time.

See Scriptus in action at edocscriptus.com →

Sources

Superscript numbers in the text correspond to the numbered sources below.

1. **Hospice News.** Report details hospice industry outlook. 2023. finance.yahoo.com
2. **Hospice News.** How the labor shortage affects frontline hospice workers. 2023. hospicenews.com
3. **Hospice News.** The state of the hospice nursing workforce. 2024. hospicenews.com
4. **Cho E-J, Cho HH.** Factors influencing compassion fatigue among hospice and palliative care unit nurses. ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/PMC8872521
5. **PubMed Central.** ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/PMC10179998
6. **Slocum-Gori S, Hemsworth D, Chan WW, Carson A, Kazanjian A.** Understanding compassion satisfaction, compassion fatigue and burnout: a survey of the hospice palliative care workforce. Palliat Med. 2013;27:172–8.
7. **Abendroth M, Flannery J.** Predicting the risk of compassion fatigue: a study of hospice nurses. J Hosp Palliat Nurs. 2006;8:346–56.
8. **Hospice News.** The biggest barriers to hospice recruiting. 2022. hospicenews.com
9. **PubMed Central.** ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/PMC5788077
10. **PubMed Central.** ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/PMC7503310
11. **Hospice News.** 3 ways hospices are managing rising costs of care delivery. 2022. hospicenews.com
12. **Hospice News.** As more hospices close their doors, staffing strains are becoming crystalized. 2022. hospicenews.com
13. **Hospice News.** Where hospices are investing their 2024 recruitment, retention dollars. 2024. hospicenews.com
14. **NurseRegistry.** 8 challenges in home healthcare staffing. nurseregistry.com
15. **NAHC.** Innovative gig staffing ideas for your home care and hospice organization. nahc.org
16. **Gorn.** The gig economy in healthcare staffing. gornapp.com
17. **HWL.** Adapting to the gig economy: benefits for healthcare staffing strategies. hwlworks.com
18. **Becker's Hospital Review.** Beyond travel nurses: is a gig workforce the cure for hospital staffing woes? beckershospitalreview.com
19. **NHPCO.** Hospice staffing framework. nhpco.org
20. **HR.com.** Gig economy: addressing legal compliance and benefits. hr.com
21. **Caspio.** HR compliance in the gig economy. caspio.com
22. **PubMed Central.** ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/PMC11047988
23. **Health Recovery Solutions.** Hospice & palliative care services: the case for RPM and telehealth. healthrecoverysolutions.com
24. **Edoc Service.** Company blog. edoconboard.com/blog
25. **Scriptus by Edoc Service.** edocscriptus.com

edoc

Scriptus

Human-verified clinical documentation for hospice and palliative care, built on more than two decades of transcription expertise.

